

MISTRESSES, MAIDS, AND governesses

19TH-CENTURY AUSTRALIA

In the early 1800s there was a significant gender imbalance in the colony of New South Wales and in the new settlements of Port Philip and Adelaide. Male convicts, soldiers, and free settlers greatly outnumbered women in these regions. Good female servants were highly sought after, and English women in Australia who wrote to their relatives often expressed their concerns over finding suitable

servants and governesses for their children. Except for those who had been convicted of violent crimes, female convicts were placed as soon as they arrived as cooks and housemaids. Former convicts, known as emancipists, who were literate were considered unsuitable as governesses, because if they could read it was often the case that they had been convicted of forgery or political crimes. For those lucky



► Colonizing a continent

A white couple pose with their Aboriginal employees in 1855. Aboriginal staff earned a tiny fraction of the wages paid to white domestic workers, leading to accusations of slavery.